DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Did the Prophets See an Image of God?

Daat Tevunot §180-186

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §180 (end) to §186 (section 10, end of part 2 and part 3) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 13 November 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: what is prophecy?

Page 610. The Rabbi reviewed last week by asking the group.

- **Definition.** Connection to Hashem, experiencing the Shekhinah with 100% certainty. A prophet has no doubt.
- **Two kinds.** Prophecies about God's attributes, and about His actions.
- **Which may need help?** Prophecies about actions. The prophet is given an image and may need help interpreting it. Prophecies about attributes are always clear, because leaving a doubt there is too dangerous and could lead to heresy.
- **Contradictions.** At Sinai, Hazal say, God showed several faces. Is He a lion or an eagle? These are different emanations, and that is fine. The content of prophecy never contradicts itself: God will not tell one prophet one thing and another prophet the opposite. But the images may.

End of §180: why contradiction is possible

The images are not independent things; they are creations of God, and He decides how to bring them. He is not bound by the laws of physical nature, which apply only to physical things. But nothing is in vain: each image teaches an attribute or an action. The image itself is not what matters; what matters is the information you draw from it. So images can contradict.

A participant summed up: the image is tailored to a particular prophet. Exactly.

Prophecy, Ruah HaKodesh and dreams

Asked about prophecy in dreams, the Rabbi explained (noting that the Ramhal covers this more in Derech Hashem). When a person receives prophecy, he loses his physical senses: all prophets fell to the ground as if in a seizure, by day or night. Only Moshe stayed standing.

But prophecy does not just fall on someone asleep in bed. It has to be prepared for and worked towards; you are "constantly going to school". God appearing to Avimelekh or Pharaoh at night was not prophecy. Shemuel, called three times, was awake enough to hear and ask what was happening.

He set out four levels:

1. **Information in a dream**, which may be true or false, since it can come from bad forces.
2. **A spark of Ruah HaKodesh**, which most of us have probably experienced: a moment when you see the hand of Hashem clearly and everything falls into place.
3. **Ruah HaKodesh** proper, understanding something, which still exists today.
4. **Nevuah**, prophecy, which we do not have today.

§181-183: "You saw no image"

The Neshamah asks: you have told me about images of God, smiling and laughing, lion and eagle. But the verse in Vaethanan says, "You saw no image (temunah)." The Sekhel says: I can give you a stronger question. The verses contradict each other. In Bemidbar it says of Moshe, "he gazes at the image of Hashem", and other verses describe a likeness of a man above the throne. Ask on the verses, not on me.

§184: what the prophet knows

The Sekhel answers. "To whom will you liken Me?" God has no image, and He would never make a prophet stumble into thinking He does. There could be no greater stumbling block. Rather, the image is there to give further information.

A prophet's understanding is engraved in him, part of his fabric. Three things are clear to him at once:

1. It is God who is revealing Himself to him.
2. He must not "gaze", not with the physical eye and not even spiritually.
3. God is creating this image, and through it the prophet is to receive information.

This, says the Ramhal, is what "by the hand of the prophets I give images" means. The prophet's soul grasps the image only together with the knowledge that it is an image created by God, not God Himself.

So Moshe told Israel there was no image. God created images for them precisely because He has no image; the images prove it. The Rabbi asked the group what "you saw no image" then means. Answer: you saw no image of God. You did see images that God created to convey what you received at Sinai. The verse is slightly elliptical.

A participant summed up the definition: the prophet knows he is with Hashem, receives images, knows they must be interpreted, and knows they are God's creation. "Perfect."

§185-186: the mirror

The Neshamah asks: but the verse about Moshe says "he gazes at the image of Hashem", not an image God created. How do you explain that?

The Sekhel answers that even the image the prophet sees can be called "the image of Hashem", because it is clear to him that it comes from God, and through it he understands the Almighty.

The analogy: seeing a friend in a mirror, an aspaklaria. The Rabbi noted that Hazal always use this Aramaic word, perhaps because there is no Hebrew one; one participant recalled the women's copper mirrors in the Mishkan. If I look in a mirror and see my friend across the room, I am not looking at him with my eyes; I see his reflection. From it I learn about him, his clothes, his face. And I know I am looking at a mirror. Change the mirror, as children do playing with two mirrors, and the image changes.

So "you saw no image" means you did not see God Himself. "The image of Hashem" means you saw something of God in the mirror. The prophet knows that he is looking at a mirror, and also that it is God in the mirror.

A preview: Moshe's prophecy

Then how was Moshe different? He asked "show me Your glory" and was told "you will see My back". The Rabbi said Moshe too could not go beyond the mirror; that is impossible. But Moshe saw through a clear mirror, while other prophets saw through an unclear one, and through a chain of mirrors reflecting each other. That is why Moshe needed no riddles: his image came straight and undistorted. Other prophets' images could be distorted, so they had to interpret.

Next week: the rest of this chapter, and the next one on the purpose of prophetic images.

Summary

- Prophecy is certain connection with God, about His attributes or His actions; images may conflict because they are God's creations, not God.
- Dreams, a spark of Ruah HaKodesh, Ruah HaKodesh and Nevuah are four different levels; only the last is absent today.
- "You saw no image" means no image of God Himself, only images He created; the prophet always knows this.
- "The image of Hashem" means God seen as in a mirror, an aspaklaria: a reflection, recognised as such.
- Moshe saw through one clear mirror; other prophets through unclear and multiple mirrors, which is why they needed riddles.

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